

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 160

Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

Region: Africa

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Section Title(S)

Sexual taboos • The Rules Governing Ngweko

The girl is expected to be a virgin in the sense of having an unperforated hymenal membrane when she marries. Any intercourse which may result in pregnancy before marriage is strictly forbidden. Any young man who may render a girl pregnant (*kohira moiretu ihu*) is severely punished by the *kiama* (tribal council). The fine for this is nine sheep or goats and three big, fat sheep (*ndorome*) as the *kiama* fees. Besides this, the man is made a social outcast or "sent to Covertry" (*kohingwo*) by all the young men and girls of his own age-group. Punishment is also extended to the girl. She pays a fine by providing a feast to the men and the girls of her age-group. She is also liable to ridicule (*kohingwo* and *gocambio*).

626
Social Control

684
Sex And Marital
Offenses

836
Premarital Sex
Relations

If a man is detected by a girl trying to loosen her garments during the night of *ngweko* she generally reports the matter to all her friends in the district. The matter is taken to the age-group meeting (*getongano kia riika*). Such a man would be ostracised by his friends and would be debarred from having *ngweko* with other girls, as they would not trust or have confidence in him. These guiding principles, ingrained in the very souls of the young men and women, serve as checks to sexual promiscuity, for, unless a man knows a girl very well, he would not run the risk of suggesting copulation to her lest she should not only refuse, but tell other girls and have him *kohingwo* ("sent to Covertry").

626
Social Control

839
Miscellaneous Sex
Behavior

 Sexual taboos

Between members of the same family all forms of erotic connection are considered a great sin. Although there is  161 great freedom among young people in their courtship and amorous experiments, brothers and sisters would not dare to indulge in these activities in one another's presence. In bachelor huts, where young people meet freely, brother and sister cannot be

834
General Sex
Restrictions

835

present together at the same time, except on purely social occasions when there is no sex-play. For example, if a brother knows that his sister has a lover in a particular bachelor-hut, he makes a point of not visiting the hut during the times when she is frequenting it. The same thing applies to the sister. This rule is also observed in dances and other ceremonies. No brother could take his sister, or any close female relative, as a partner on such occasions. During festival dances, where people from various districts meet and dance together, it is not always possible to recognise a relative who comes from far away, and a man may sometimes be seen dancing with his cousin by mistake. When this happens, people who know will start laughing and joking to warn the young man of his error. At once the two separate and find other partners, and sometimes a present is given to the girl by way of apology from the man.

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